SURVIVAL-TIPS

Water & Sanitation

Finding, collecting, treating, storing, and safely managing water and sanitation.

Stage 03 • Generated 2026-10-29 • 14 knowledge entries

How to use this handbook

Use this guide as a learning aid, not as a substitute for official emergency instructions or expert assessment. Every AI-extracted tip must be reviewed before it is treated as verified guidance. Never infer that a wild plant, mushroom, water source, or improvised material is safe based on appearance alone.

1. Include All 10 Required Elements in a Public Notice

Ensure every public notice contains the EPA Public Notification Rule's 10 mandatory elements to meet regulatory requirements and provide clear information to the public.

Steps

1. Identify the 10 required elements: violation description, contaminant(s), timing, health effects, vulnerable populations, alternate water use, consumer actions, system response, compliance timeline, contact info.

2. Draft the notice incorporating each element.

3. Review for completeness before distribution.

Warnings

• Incomplete notices may violate EPA regulations and reduce public trust.

Review status: needs_review • Category: water

Source: Preparing an Advisory Drinking Water Advisory Communications Toolbox | Water, Sanitation, & Hygiene-related Emergencies & and Outbreaks | Healthy Water | CDC — https://archive.cdc.gov/www_cdc_gov/healthywater/emergency/dwa-comm-toolbox/during/preparing.html

2. Translate Messages Through Community Partners

Use trusted community partners or professional translators to produce accessible versions of advisories, avoiding automated translation tools.

Steps

1. Identify local community organizations with language expertise.

2. Provide source material and context to translators.

3. Review translated drafts for accuracy and cultural relevance.

4. Distribute translated advisories via appropriate channels.

Warnings

• Online dictionaries or generic software can produce mistranslations that misinform the public.

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3. Employ Multiple Communication Channels

Disseminate advisories through a mix of traditional media, SMS, social media, and variable message signs to reach diverse audiences.

Steps

1. Select channels based on audience demographics and message length constraints.

2. Prepare abbreviated messages for channels with limited space.

3. Schedule simultaneous releases across chosen platforms.

Warnings

• Relying on a single channel may leave segments of the population uninformed.

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4. Encourage Notice Sharing

Include a statement urging recipients to forward the advisory to others, amplifying reach and community awareness.

Steps

1. Add a brief encouragement line to the notice, e.g., "Please share this notice with neighbors and friends."

2. Place the statement prominently in the notice and digital posts.

Warnings

• Omitting this step may limit the advisory’s dissemination beyond initial recipients.

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5. Use Abbreviated Messages for Space■Limited Channels

Craft concise messages that convey essential actions for channels like SMS, social media, and broadcast alerts.

Steps

1. Identify the core action (e.g., boil water), location, contact info, and where to get more info.

2. Format the message to fit character limits of each channel.

3. Test readability before sending.

Warnings

• Too brief messages may omit critical safety information.

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Source: Preparing an Advisory Drinking Water Advisory Communications Toolbox | Water, Sanitation, & Hygiene-related Emergencies & and Outbreaks | Healthy Water | CDC — https://archive.cdc.gov/www_cdc_gov/healthywater/emergency/dwa-comm-toolbox/during/preparing.html

6. Customize Chemical Contaminant Advisories with Expert Input

When chemical contaminants are involved, consult experts and tailor messages to specific health impacts and exposure routes.

Steps

1. Engage chemical safety experts to assess health risks and exposure pathways.

2. Use the Message Mapping Template and Sample Message Map to adapt the advisory language.

3. Include specific guidance relevant to the contaminant type.

Warnings

• Generic microbial advisories may not address chemical■specific risks.

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7. Rapid Assessment and Rehabilitation of Damaged Water Systems

Quickly evaluate and repair broken water infrastructure to restore safe water supply.

Steps

1. Conduct rapid assessment of water system damage
2. Identify critical repair points
3. Mobilize repair teams and materials
4. Test water quality post-repair
5. Communicate status to community

Warnings

• Requires trained personnel; risk of contamination if not properly sealed

Review status: needs_review • Category: water

Source: Emergency WASH - IFRC's Water Security/WASH portal — https://wash.ifrc.org/our-work/emergency-wash/

8. Safe Drinking Water Provision via Water Treatment Tanks

Construct water treatment tanks to provide safe drinking water in emergencies.

Steps

1. Identify suitable site
2. Build tank with appropriate materials
3. Install filtration and disinfection systems
4. Fill and test water
5. Distribute to community

Warnings

• Ensure proper maintenance to avoid contamination

Review status: needs_review • Category: water

Source: Emergency WASH - IFRC's Water Security/WASH portal — https://wash.ifrc.org/our-work/emergency-wash/

9. Building Toilets and Hygiene Facilities

Construct toilets and hygiene facilities to reduce disease spread.

Steps

1. Assess community needs
2. Design appropriate toilet type
3. Source materials
4. Build and install
5. Provide handwashing stations

Warnings

• Must consider cultural acceptance and waste disposal

Review status: needs_review • Category: sanitation

Source: Emergency WASH - IFRC's Water Security/WASH portal — https://wash.ifrc.org/our-work/emergency-wash/

10. Boil Water During Advisories

When a boil water advisory is issued, heat water to a rolling boil for at least one minute to kill pathogens such as Cryptosporidium.

Steps

1. Check local advisories for boil water orders.
2. Collect water from a safe source.
3. Heat water on a stove or other heat source until it reaches a rolling boil.
4. Maintain the boil for at least 1 minute.
5. Cool and store in clean containers.
6. Use the boiled water for drinking, cooking, and brushing teeth.
7. Reboil if water is stored for more than 24 hours.

Warnings

• Do not use water that has been stored in contaminated containers.

• Avoid boiling water that may contain chemical contaminants.

Review status: needs_review • Category: water

Source: Responding to a Water, Sanitation, & Hygiene (WASH)-related Emergency | Water, Sanitation, & Hygiene-related Emergencies & and Outbreaks | Healthy Water | CDC — https://archive.cdc.gov/www_cdc_gov/healthywater/emergency/planning-training-response/responding.html

11. Follow Bulk Water Hauling Guidelines

Use the Connecticut Department of Public Health bulk water hauling guidelines to safely transport large volumes of water during emergencies.

Steps

1. Obtain the bulk water hauling guidelines PDF.
2. Select appropriate containers and transport vehicles.
3. Ensure containers are clean and sealed.
4. Transport water to the destination following local regulations.
5. Store water in a cool, shaded area.
6. Label containers with contents and date.
7. Dispose of any contaminated water properly.

Warnings

• Do not transport water in containers that have previously held chemicals.

• Ensure vehicles are clean to avoid contamination.

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12. Clean and Disinfect Water Storage Tanks

Use WHO guidelines to disinfect water storage tanks and tankers to prevent contamination during emergencies.

Steps

1. Gather WHO cleaning and disinfecting guidelines PDF.
2. Inspect tanks for cracks or leaks.
3. Clean interior surfaces with soap and water.
4. Apply disinfectant according to WHO instructions.
5. Rinse thoroughly to remove residues.
6. Refill with clean water.
7. Check for any remaining contamination before use.

Warnings

• Do not use disinfectants that are not approved for potable water.

• Avoid over■dilution of disinfectant which reduces effectiveness.

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Source: Responding to a Water, Sanitation, & Hygiene (WASH)-related Emergency | Water, Sanitation, & Hygiene-related Emergencies & and Outbreaks | Healthy Water | CDC — https://archive.cdc.gov/www_cdc_gov/healthywater/emergency/planning-training-response/responding.html

13. Practice Handwashing and Diapering After Emergencies

Follow CDC handwashing and diapering practices to reduce disease spread in emergency settings.

Steps

1. Wash hands with soap and water for at least 20 seconds.
2. Use hand sanitizer if soap is unavailable.
3. Set up diapering stations with clean diapers and wipes.
4. Dispose of diapers in sealed bags.
5. Clean diapering surfaces with disinfectant.
6. Wash hands after diapering.

Warnings

• Avoid using contaminated water for handwashing.

• Do not reuse diapers or wipes.

Review status: needs_review • Category: other

Source: Responding to a Water, Sanitation, & Hygiene (WASH)-related Emergency | Water, Sanitation, & Hygiene-related Emergencies & and Outbreaks | Healthy Water | CDC — https://archive.cdc.gov/www_cdc_gov/healthywater/emergency/planning-training-response/responding.html

14. Handle Community Wastewater Systems After Emergencies

Use CDC guidance to manage community wastewater systems and minimize disease spread.

Steps

1. Inspect systems for damage or overflow.
2. Seal off damaged sections to prevent contamination.
3. Use temporary sanitation solutions if needed.
4. Monitor water quality regularly.
5. Report any issues to local health authorities.

Warnings

• Do not enter contaminated wastewater areas without proper protection.

• Avoid using untreated wastewater for irrigation.

Review status: needs_review • Category: other

Source: Responding to a Water, Sanitation, & Hygiene (WASH)-related Emergency | Water, Sanitation, & Hygiene-related Emergencies & and Outbreaks | Healthy Water | CDC — https://archive.cdc.gov/www_cdc_gov/healthywater/emergency/planning-training-response/responding.html